

HCOS™ Insight

Great Products Don't Always Win

Looking Beyond the Product to Understand the System

The Question

A developer recently shared a common frustration.

After spending more than a year building an open-source AI agent, continually adding features, improving the product, and pivoting multiple times, adoption remained low while newer competitors quickly gained attention.

The question they asked was:

"What are we doing wrong?"

From an HCOS™ perspective, that may not be the most helpful question.

A better question is:

"What system determines whether an open-source AI project gets adopted?"

That simple shift moves the conversation from self-blame to understanding.

Think Well

This isn't a story about failure.

It's a story about a team that invested time, creativity, and energy into building something they believe in.

Their disappointment is understandable.

When our work doesn't receive the response we hoped for, it's natural to wonder if we've failed.

But healthy systems remind us that outcomes are rarely determined by a single factor.

Instead of immediately asking:

- Is our product bad?
- Is our name wrong?
- Is our interface ugly?

HCOS™ encourages us to remain curious.

There may be larger system pressures influencing the outcome.

Teach Well

Imagine Two Restaurants.

One serves outstanding food.

The other serves good food.

The second restaurant happens to be located on the busiest street in town.

Food critics write about it.

Friends recommend it.

Photos appear across social media.

Soon, everyone is eating there.

Does that automatically mean it serves the better meal?

Not necessarily.

The difference may not be the food.

It may be the system surrounding it.

Products work the same way.

Building a great product is only one part of adoption.

People must also discover it, understand it, trust it, try it, and recommend it.

Understand Well

Looking at the Whole System

HCOS™ encourages us to examine the system rather than focusing only on the product.

Workload

Can a new user understand what the product does within the first 30 seconds?

Or does learning it feel like work?

Workflow

Is it immediately clear why someone should choose this product instead of another?

Does it solve an obvious problem?

Policies

Has the team established a clear vision, or are frequent pivots making the product harder to understand?

Metrics

Are GitHub stars becoming the primary measure of success?

Or is the team learning from:

- Active users
- Community engagement
- Contributor growth
- Successful real-world use

Healthy metrics measure meaningful value—not just visibility.

Resources

Is enough time being invested in:

- Documentation
- Tutorials
- Community conversations
- Demonstrations
- User support

Building software is only one part of building adoption.

Leadership Decisions

Has the team been reacting to competitors?

Or are they building a clear identity that people immediately recognize?

Daily Operations

Does every new feature improve the experience?

Or is increasing complexity making the product harder to understand?

Sometimes the greatest opportunity isn't adding another feature.

It's making the existing experience simpler.

Recovery Time

Healthy teams also need time to reflect.

Instead of continuously building more, pause long enough to learn what users are actually experiencing.

Learning is productive work.

Protect with Wisdom, Compassion, and Presence

Wisdom

Separate observations from assumptions.

Observation:

The project has not gained widespread adoption.

Assumption:

Therefore, the product is not valuable.

Those are not the same conclusion.

Adoption depends on many interconnected parts of the system.

Compassion

Creating open-source software requires significant effort.

Many successful projects experienced long periods of slow growth before reaching broader adoption.

Curiosity is often more helpful than self-criticism.

Presence

The people who can teach us the most are often new users.

Watch someone use the product for the first time.

Where do they hesitate?

Where do they become confused?

Where do they become excited?

Those moments reveal opportunities that analytics alone cannot.

Grow Well

Instead of immediately building more features, consider spending time understanding the adoption journey.

Ask:

- Can someone explain what this product does in one sentence?
- What problem does it solve better than anything else?
- What is the first "aha" moment for a new user?
- If only one feature remained, which one would people truly miss?
- What makes people recommend this product to others?

Healthy systems do not become more successful simply because they become more complex.

They become more successful because they make it easier for people to discover value, build trust, and experience meaningful outcomes.

HCOS™ Perspective

The most important question may not be:

"How can we build more?"

It may be:

"How can we make it easier for people to discover, understand, trust, adopt, and benefit from what we've already built?"

Sometimes the bottleneck isn't the software.

It's the path between discovering it, understanding it, trying it, and telling someone else about it.

That path is part of the system too.

Key Takeaway

Great products do not always win because they have the most features.

They succeed when people can quickly understand their purpose, experience their value, and confidently recommend them to others.

HCOS™ reminds us that healthy innovation begins by understanding the whole system—not just the product.